

After watching the "How Persons with Disabilities Use the Web" panel, I learned a lot about the challenges people with disabilities face when using the internet. Before this class, I never considered how people with motor or visibility disabilities navigate the internet. After this panel, I also considered how people with those disabilities and people with sensory disabilities need special tools to successfully navigate the internet. It was eye-opening to hear firsthand from people like Jamie Knight how disabilities such as sensitivity to light, vision, and the tendency to filter out noisy applications navigate the internet.

What surprised me most was the amount of consideration that goes into building a fully accessible website given all ranges of disabilities. One of the panelists mentioned using a screen reader, which reads out text aloud to help blind users navigate the web. Additionally, another panelist mentioned experiencing a traumatic brain injury that confuses their short-term and long-term memory so when navigating inaccessible webpages it gets frustrating because of complicated multi-step processes on various websites. The process isn't as seamless as I initially thought it would be from the first few homeworks and projects in this class. Another panelist discussed using voice recognition technology for people with limited motor skills, which can help them control their devices by speaking commands. I never fully considered that some of these mobile applications are the main tool people use to interact with others through speech and how important it is to ensure that people with multiple disabilities are able to navigate applications that are made to assist only one disability. After hearing the panelist I now understand the true importance of testing applications and web pages with people with disabilities before deployment. Asking people with neurological disabilities along with people with physical disabilities to test accessibility would be something to keep in mind from now on. For the Accessibility Audit, I would consider the troubles people with short-term memory go through when testing the website.

Two takeaways from the panel: Accessibility is a fundamental requirement to consider when building websites. Websites should be designed by testing functionality of different features with people with and without disabilities. Additionally, we must cover a range of disabilities to ensure everyone is able to utilize the website. Secondly, the technology people use to interact with the web such as screen readers, voice recognition, and keyboard shortcuts can still not be enough for people to navigate poorly designed websites. Ensuring people do not have to use these tools to try to figure out how to navigate the website is important because the website should be simple and straightforward to go through.

Based on the panel, It's clear that accessibility isn't just about adding alt text to images or making sure a website is navigable with a keyboard. A more thorough approach is needed by taking into account all of the technologies that people with different disabilities use and ensuring that accessible technologies also work when being applied to the website. Some questions after listening to the panel: How do companies balance accessibility with the desire to create complex technology that is tailored to a specific group of the same background that could include those with disabilities? Also, what are the best practices for making features like website forms and videos accessible to people with all types of disabilities?